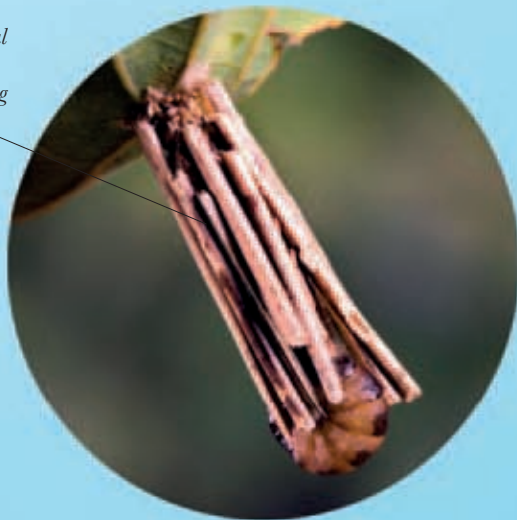


Mobile home

Some animals make portable homes just for themselves. This cluster of tiny sticks is a case made by a bagworm—a moth caterpillar that feeds on leaves. The sticks are fastened together with silk, and they camouflage the caterpillar from insect-eating birds. Males eventually emerge from their cases to mate, but females often stay inside all their lives.

Plant material disguises silk bag containing bagworm



Show home

Hanging upside down, a male southern masked weaver uses his bill to stitch another blade of grass into his nest. Male birds do all the building work—first, collecting strips of flexible, green grass and then weaving and knotting them into a hollow, hanging ball. The birds become more skilled at constructing their woven nests each time they build. Once finished, the bird hangs beneath the nest and flutters his wings, inviting females to mate and move in.

Woven grass strips form domed nest chamber

Burrow entrance

Nest made of grass and fur



Underground maze

Many insects dig burrows, but the largest tunnels are made by mammals. European rabbit colonies live in a warren—a network of burrows that can have many entrances and more than 800 ft (250 m) of tunnels. The rabbits graze in the open, but they rarely stray far from the warren. At the first sign of danger, they disappear to safety underground.

Building materials

Animals build their homes with the materials they find in their local habitat and many use them in their natural form. Some animals, however, shape or process their materials first—perhaps by chewing them, or by mixing them with spit, or saliva. Other animals can produce building materials, such as spider's silk or beeswax, with their own bodies.



Leaves

Australian green ants make bag-shaped nests from folded leaves. Chains of ants pull the leaves into position, and then glue them together with the sticky silk that is produced by their grubs.



Foam

Foam-nest frogs whip up their own mucus to make hanging nests for their eggs in trees. Once the tadpoles develop in the foam, they wriggle out of the nest and drop into pools and streams.



Clay

Some termites build their nests from wood fibers, but the largest mounds are made from particles of clay mixed with saliva. They tower up to 30 ft (9 m) high and have deep, underground passages.



Grass

The tiny harvest mouse collects blades of grass, which it shreds and uses to weave a ball-shaped nest. The nest is attached to grass stems about 1 ft (30 cm) above the ground.



Wood fibers

Common wasps use their jaws to chew up dead wood fibers and mix them with saliva to form a paste. The wasps spread out the paste in sheets, which dry to form the paper walls of their nest.